have prompted the Congress hand with Rai. His replacement, veteran Pramod Tiwari's daughter Aradhana Mishra 'Mona', is commonly being explained through the caste logic: while a doughty fighter who raised the party's combat-worthiness, Rai is a Bhumihar from the east, with limited appeal at that level. Mona is more canonical Brahmin and can tap into that pan-UP community's old affinity for the Congress—in case it's feeling nostalgic. But more to the point, Mona may be softer in conducting seat-sharing talks with the SP, compared to the more blunt and outspoken Rai.



SHIFTING TIDES UP Congress chief Mona Mishra after Rahul Gandhi's acquittal in defamation case, Lucknow, Oct. 26; (below) Rahul with Akhilesh

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A DOUBLES TEAM

The SP-Congress partnership in UP is built around a simple idea. Akhilesh brings the ground-level sinew, Rahul brings the national narrative. It may have had uneven results in its earlier editions—especially in 2017, when the duo famously campaigned together as 'UP ke Do Ladke' (The Two Boys of UP) but were swept away in the tidal surge of support for Yogi Adityanath.

In every attempt thereafter, the same diagnosis was made: the deal at the top was subject to mistranslation on the ground, the cadre didn't mix well, the vote bases not at all. But each time, some of the ground dynamics were getting refined. In 2024, things actually fell into place and the duo won 43 of UP's 80 Lok Sabha seats. That has raised the stakes as the 2027 assembly election draws closer. The material question of seat-sharing is acquiring sharpness—wielded callously, it can slice right through brotherhood bonds.

The jostling that usually stays backstage became overt when Akhilesh sallied into Raebareli in September 24. Six days later, his absence at an INDIA bloc meeting in Delhi also did not go unnoticed. The SP said with a poker-face that he had pre-scheduled engagements. Then, on October 6, Akhilesh rejoined the INDIA frontlines by participating in a 'March to the Election Commission'.

The nub of all this mutual gamesmanship is seat-sharing. Akhilesh has yet to say anything concrete, but signals are that the SP wants to retain the overwhelming majority of seats. Last heard, the Congress was talking about at least 150 of UP's 403 assembly seats. With Mona, it may ask nicely.

That constraint was not mandated down the line under Rai. No clearer proof was needed of that than the public sparring between two MPs from western UP: the SP's urbane, SOAS-returned Iqra Hasan and Congress blunderbuss Imran Masood. In late September, they had a real go at each other's parties—Masood taunting Akhilesh, and Iqra doubting the Congress's ability to do anything on its own.

That debate inverts the logic of the alliance. The SP credits the 37 seats it won in 2024 to its expanding PDA umbrella. But the 'D' there denotes Dalits, and the thawing of a hitherto hostile social bloc owed not a little to the enabling presence of Rahul—a fact not fully reflected in the party tally of six. The alliance is more than a salad bowl now, but the recipe won't work unless the ingredients come together. ■

Takeaways



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- **Mystery posters in Lucknow generate heat by saying the Congress wants 200 seats**
- **Akhilesh calls it a BJP ruse to sow divisions in alliance**
- **But in September, SP boss had chosen Rahul's borough Raebareli to kick off PDA yatra**
- **New state chief Mona Mishra said to be softer in negotiations than Ajay Rai**